

breathing a cry of grief and anger. He stopped upon the threshold to listen to what was addressed from the court to the window.

'Miserable wretches!' said the Abbé, 'you did not fight, then?'

'Like lions.'

'Say like cowards.'

'Monsieur!'

'A hundred men accustomed to war, sword in hand, are worth ten thousand archers in a surprise. Where is Menneville, that boaster, that braggart, who was to come back either dead or a conqueror?'

'Well, monsieur, he kept his word. He is dead!'

'Dead! Who killed him?'

'A demon disguised as a man, a giant armed with ten flaming swords—a madman, who at one blow extinguished the fire, put down the riot, and caused a hundred musketeers to rise up out of the pavement of the Grève.'

Fouquet raised his brow, streaming with sweat, murmuring, 'Oh! Lyodot and D'Eymetis! dead! dead! and I dishonoured.'

The Abbé turned round, and perceiving his brother, despairing and livid, 'Come, come,' said he, 'it is a blow of fate, monsieur; we must not lament thus.

Our attempt has failed because God—'

'Be silent, Abbé! be silent!' cried Fouquet; 'your excuses are blasphemies.

Order that man up here, and let him relate the details of this terrible event.'

'But, brother—'

'Obey, monsieur!'

The Abbé made a sign, and in half a minute the man's step was heard upon the stairs. At the same time Gourville appeared behind Fouquet, like the guardian angel of the superintendent, pressing one finger on his lips to enjoin observation even amidst the bursts of his grief. The minister resumed all the serenity that human strength left at the disposal of a heart half broken with sorrow. Danicamp appeared. 'Make your report,' said Gourville.

'Monsieur,' replied the messenger, 'we received orders to carry off the prisoners, and to cry "Vive Colbert!" whilst carrying them off.'

'To burn them alive, was it not, Abbé?' interrupted Gourville.

'Yes, yes, the order was given to Menneville. Menneville knew what was to be done, and Menneville is dead.'

This news appeared rather to reassure Gourville than to sadden him.

'Yes, certainly to burn them alive,' said the Abbé, eagerly.

'Granted, monsieur, granted,' said the man, looking into the eyes and the faces of the two interlocutors, to ascertain what there was profitable or disadvantageous to himself in telling the truth.

'Now, proceed,' said Gourville.

'The prisoners,' cried Danicamp, 'were brought to the Grève, and the people, in a fury, insisted upon their being burnt instead of being hung.'

'And the people were right,' said the Abbé. 'Go on.'

'But,' resumed the man, 'at the moment the archers were broken, at the moment the fire was set to one of the houses of the Place destined to serve as a funeral-pile for the guilty, this fury, this demon, this giant of whom I told you, and who, we had been informed, was the proprietor of the house in question, aided by a young man who accompanied him, threw out of the window those who kept the fire, called to his assistance the musketeers who were in the crowd, leaped himself from the window of the first story into the Place, and plied his sword so desperately that the victory was restored to the archers, the prisoners were retaken, and Menneville killed. When once recaptured, the condemned were executed in three minutes.' Fouquet, in spite of his self-command, could not prevent a deep groan escaping him.

'And this man, the proprietor of the house, what is his name?' said the Abbé.

'I cannot tell you, not having even been able to get sight of him; my post had been appointed in the garden, and I remained at my post: only the affair was related to me as I repeat it. I was ordered, when once the affair was at an end, to come at best speed and announce to you the manner in which it finished. According to this order, I set out, full gallop, and here I am.'

'Very well, monsieur, we have nothing else to ask of you,' said the Abbé, more and more dejected, in proportion as the moment approached for finding himself alone with his brother.

'Have you been paid?' asked Gourville.

'Partly, monsieur,' replied Danicamp.

'Here are twenty pistols. Begone, monsieur, and never forget to defend, as this time has been done, the true interests of the king.'

'Yes, monsieur,' said the man, bowing and pocketing the money. After which he went out. Scarcely had the door closed after him when Fouquet,

who had remained motionless, advanced with a rapid step and stood between the Abbé and Gourville. Both of them at the same time opened their mouths to speak to him. 'No excuses,' said he, 'no recriminations against anybody. If I had not been a false friend I should not have confided to any one the care of delivering Lyodot and D'Eymeris. I alone am guilty; to me alone are reproaches and remorse due. Leave me, Abbé.'

'And yet, monsieur, you will not prevent me,' replied the latter, 'from endeavouring to find out the miserable fellow who has intervened to the advantage of M. Colbert in this so well-arranged affair; for, if it is good policy to love our friends dearly, I do not believe that is bad which consists in obstinately pursuing our enemies.'

'A truce to policy, Abbé; begone, I beg of you, and do not let me hear any more of you till I send for you; what we most need is circumspection and silence. You have a terrible example before you, gentlemen: no reprisals, I forbid them.'

'There are no orders,' grumbled the Abbé, 'which will prevent me from avenging a family affront upon the guilty person.'

'And I,' cried Fouquet, in that imperative tone to which one feels there is nothing to reply, 'if you entertain one thought, one single thought, which is not the absolute expression of my will, I will have you cast into the Bastille two hours after that thought has manifested itself. Regulate your conduct accordingly, Abbé.'

The Abbé coloured and bowed. Fouquet made a sign to Gourville to follow him, and was already directing his steps towards his cabinet, when the usher announced with a loud voice: 'Monsieur le Chevalier d'Artagnan.'

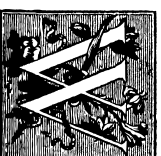
'Who is he?' said Fouquet, negligently, to Gourville.

'An ex-lieutenant of his majesty's musketeers,' replied Gourville, in the same tone. Fouquet did not even take the trouble to reflect, and resumed his walk. 'I beg your pardon, monseigneur!' said Gourville, 'but I have remembered; this brave man has quitted the king's service, and probably comes to receive an installment of some pension or other.'

'Devil take him!' said Fouquet, 'why does he choose his opportunity so ill?' 'Permit me then, monseigneur, to announce your refusal to him; for he is one of my acquaintance, and is a man whom, in our present circumstances, it would be better to have as a friend than an enemy.'

Chapter LXIII

How M. d'Eymeris's Diamond Passed into the Hands of M. d'Artagnan



MUST this violent, noisy, and bloody scene was passing on the Grève, several men, barricaded behind the gate of communication with the garden, replaced their swords in their sheaths, assisted one among them to mount a ready saddled horse which was waiting in the garden, and like a flock of startled birds, fled in all directions, some climbing the walls, others rushing out at the gates with all the fury of a panic. He who mounted the horse, and gave him the spur so sharply that the animal was near leaping the wall, this cavalier, we say, crossed the Place Baudoyer, passed like lightning before the crowd in the streets, riding against, running over and knocking down all that came in his way; and, ten minutes after, arrived at the gates of the superintendent, more out of breath than his horse. The Abbé Fouquet, at the clatter of hoofs on the pavement, appeared at a window of the court, and before even the cavalier had set foot to the ground, 'Well! Danicamp?' cried he, leaning half out of the window.

'Well, it is all over,' replied the cavalier.

'All over!' cried the Abbé. 'Then they are saved?'

'No, monsieur,' replied the cavalier, 'they are hung.'

'Hung!' repeated the Abbé, turning pale. A lateral door suddenly opened, and Fouquet appeared in the chamber, pale, distracted, with lips half opened,

'Answer him as you please,' said Fouquet.

'Eh! good Lord!' said the Abbé, still full of malice, like an egotistical man; 'tell him there is no money, particularly for musketeers.'

But scarcely had the Abbé uttered this imprudent speech, when the partly open door was thrown back, and D'Arragnan appeared.

'Eh! Monsieur Fouquet,' said he, 'I was well aware there was no money for musketeers here. Therefore I did not come to obtain any, but to have it refused. That being done, receive my thanks. I give you good-day, and will go and seek it at M. Colbert's.' And he went out, making an easy bow.

'Gourville,' said Fouquet, 'run after that man and bring him back.' Gourville obeyed, and overtook D'Arragnan on the stairs.

D'Arragnan, hearing steps behind him, turned round and perceived Gourville. 'Mordieux! my dear monsieur,' said he, 'there are sad lessons which you gentlemen of finance teach us; I come to M. Fouquet to receive a sum accorded by his majesty, and I am received like a mendicant who comes to ask charity, or a thief who comes to steal a piece of plate.'

'But you pronounced the name of M. Colbert, my dear M. d'Arragnan; you said you were going to M. Colbert's?'

'I certainly am going there, were it only to ask satisfaction of the people who try to burn houses, crying "Vive Colbert!"'

Gourville pricked up his ears. 'Oh, oh!' said he, 'you allude to what has just happened at the Grève?'

'Yes, certainly.'

'And in what did that which has taken place concern you?'

'What! do you ask me whether it concerns me or does not concern me, if M. Colbert pleases to make a funeral-pile of my house?'

'So, ho, your house—was it your house they wanted to burn?'

'Pardieu! was it!'

'Is the cabaret of the Image-de-Notre-Dame yours, then?'

'It has been this week.'

'Well, then, are you the brave captain, are you the valiant blade who dispersed those who wished to burn the condemned?'

'My dear Monsieur Gourville, put yourself in my place. I was an agent of the public force and a landlord, too. As a captain, it is my duty to have the orders of the king accomplished. As a proprietor, it is to my interest my house

should not be burnt. I have at the same time attended to the laws of interest and duty in replacing Messieurs Lyodot and D'Eymeris in the hands of the archers.'

'Then it was you who threw the man out of the window?'

'It was I, myself,' replied D'Artagnan, modestly.

'And you who killed Menneville?'

'I had that misfortune,' said D'Artagnan, bowing like a man who is being congratulated.

'It was you, then, in short, who caused the two condemned persons to be hung?'

'Instead of being burnt, yes, monsieur, and I am proud of it. I saved the poor devils from horrible tortures. Understand, my dear Monsieur de Gourville, that they wanted to burn them alive. It exceeds imagination!'

'Go, my dear Monsieur d'Artagnan, go,' said Gourville, anxious to spare Fouquet the sight of the man who had just caused him such profound grief.

'No,' said Fouquet, who had heard all from the door of the ante-chamber; 'not so; on the contrary, Monsieur d'Artagnan, come in.'

D'Artagnan wiped from the hilt of his sword a last bloody trace, which had escaped his notice, and returned. He then found himself face to face with these three men, whose countenances wore very different expressions. With the Abbé it was anger, with Gourville stupor, with Fouquet it was dejection.

'I beg your pardon, monsieur le ministre,' said D'Artagnan, 'but my time is short; I have to go to the office of the intendant, to have an explanation with Monsieur Colbert, and to receive my quarter's pension.'

'But, monsieur,' said Fouquet, 'there is money here.' D'Artagnan looked at the superintendent with astonishment. 'You have been answered inconsiderately, monsieur, I know, because I heard it,' said the minister; 'a man of your merit ought to be known by everybody.' D'Artagnan bowed. 'Have you an order?' added Fouquet.

'Yes, monsieur.'

'Give it me, I will pay you myself; come with me.' He made a sign to Gourville and the Abbé, who remained in the chamber where they were. He led D'Artagnan into his cabinet. As soon as the door was shut,—'how much is due to you, monsieur?'

'Why, something like five thousand livres, monseigneur.'

haste that he dispatched the condemned in a couple of minutes. In the meantime the people gathered around D'Artagnan,—they felicitated, they cheered him. He wiped his brow, streaming with sweat, and his sword, streaming with blood. He shrugged his shoulders at seeing Menneville writhing at his feet in the last convulsions. And, while Raoul turned away his eyes in compassion, he pointed to the musketeers the gibbets laden with their melancholy fruit. 'Poor devils!' said he, 'I hope they died blessing me, for I saved them with great difficulty.' These words caught the ear of Menneville at the moment when he himself was breathing his last sigh. A dark, ironical smile flitted across his lips; he wished to reply, but the effort hastened the snapping of the chord of life—he expired.

'Oh! all this is very frightful!' murmured Raoul: 'let us begone, monsieur le chevalier.'

'You are not wounded?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Not at all; thank you.'

'That's well! Thou art a brave fellow, mordioux! The head of the father, and the arm of Porthos. Ah! if he had been here, good Porthos, you would have seen something worth looking at.' Then as if by way of remembrance—'But where the devil can that brave Porthos be?' murmured D'Artagnan.

'Come, chevalier, pray come away,' urged Raoul.

'One minute, my friend; let me take my thirty-seven and a half pistols, and I am at your service. The house is a good property,' added D'Artagnan, as he entered the Image-de-Notre-Dame, 'but decidedly, even if it were less profitable, I should prefer its being in another quarter.'

hand. All the musketeers on the Place heard that challenging cry—all turned round at that cry, and recognized D'Artagnan. 'To the captain, to the captain!' cried they, in their turn. And the crowd opened before them as though before the prow of a vessel. At that moment D'Artagnan and Menneville found themselves face to face. 'Passage, passage!' cried Menneville, seeing that he was within an arm's length from the door.

'No one passes here,' said D'Artagnan.

'Take that, then!' said Menneville, firing his pistol almost within an arm's length. But before the cock fell, D'Artagnan had struck up Menneville's arm with the hilt of his sword and passed the blade through his body.

'I told you plainly to keep yourself quiet,' said D'Artagnan to Menneville, who rolled at his feet.

'Passage! passage!' cried the companions of Menneville, at first terrified, but soon recovering, when they found they had only to do with two men. But those two men were hundred-armed giants; the swords flew about in their hands like the burning glaive of the archangel. They pierce with its point, strike with the flat, cut with the edge; every stroke brings down a man. 'For the king!' cried D'Artagnan, to every man he struck at, that is to say, to every man that fell. This cry became the charging word for the musketeers, who, guided by it, joined D'Artagnan. During this time the archers, recovering from the panic they had undergone, charge the aggressors in the rear, and regular as mill strokes, overturn or knock down all that opposed them. The crowd, which sees swords gleaming, and drops of blood flying in the air—the crowd falls back and crushes itself. At length cries for mercy and of despair resound; that is, the farewell of the vanquished. The two condemned are again in the hands of the archers. D'Artagnan approaches them, seeing them pale and sinking: 'Console yourselves, poor men,' said he, 'you will not undergo the frightful torture with which these wretches threatened you. The king has condemned you to be hung: you shall only be hung. Go on, hang them, and it will be over.'

There is no longer anything going on at the Image-de-Notre-Dame. The fire has been extinguished with two turns of wine in default of water. The conspirators have fled by the garden. The archers are dragging the culprits to the gibbets. From this moment the affair did not occupy much time. The executioner, heedless about operating according to the rules of the art, made such

'For arrears of pay?'

'For a quarter's pay.'

'A quarter consisting of five thousand livres!' said Fouquet, fixing upon the musketeer a searching look. 'Does the king, then, give you twenty thousand livres a year?'

'Yes, monseigneur, twenty thousand livres a year. Do you think it is too much?'

'I?' cried Fouquet, and he smiled bitterly. 'If I had any knowledge of mankind, if I were—instead of being a frivolous, inconsequent, and vain spirit—of a prudent and reflective spirit; if, in a word, I had, as certain persons have known how, regulated my life, you would not receive twenty thousand livres a year, but a hundred thousand, and you would belong not to the king but to me.'

D'Artagnan coloured slightly. There is sometimes in the manner in which a eulogium is given, in the voice, in the affectionate tone, a poison so sweet, that the strongest mind is intoxicated by it. The superintendent terminated his speech by opening a drawer, and taking from it four rouleaux, which he placed before D'Artagnan. The Gascon opened one. 'Gold!' said he.

'It will be less burdensome, monsieur.'

'But, then, monsieur, these make twenty thousand livres.'

'No doubt they do.'

'But only five are due to me.'

'I wish to spare you the trouble of coming four times to my office.'

'You overwhelm me, monsieur.'

'I do only what I ought to do, monsieur le chevalier; and I hope you will not bear me any malice on account of the rude reception my brother gave you. He is of a sour, capricious disposition.'

'Monsieur,' said D'Artagnan, 'believe me, nothing would grieve me more than an excuse from you.'

'Therefore I will make no more, and will content myself with asking you a favour.'

'Oh, monsieur.'

Fouquet drew from his finger a ring worth about three thousand pistoles. 'Monsieur,' said he, 'this stone was given me by a friend of my childhood, by a man to whom you have rendered a great service.'

'A service—I?' said the musketeer; 'I have rendered a service to one of your friends?'

'You cannot have forgotten it, monsieur, for it dates this very day.'

'And that friend's name was—'

'M. d'Eymetis.'

'One of the condemned?'

'Yes, one of the victims. Well! Monsieur d'Artagnan, in return for the service you have rendered him, I beg you to accept this diamond. Do so for my sake.'

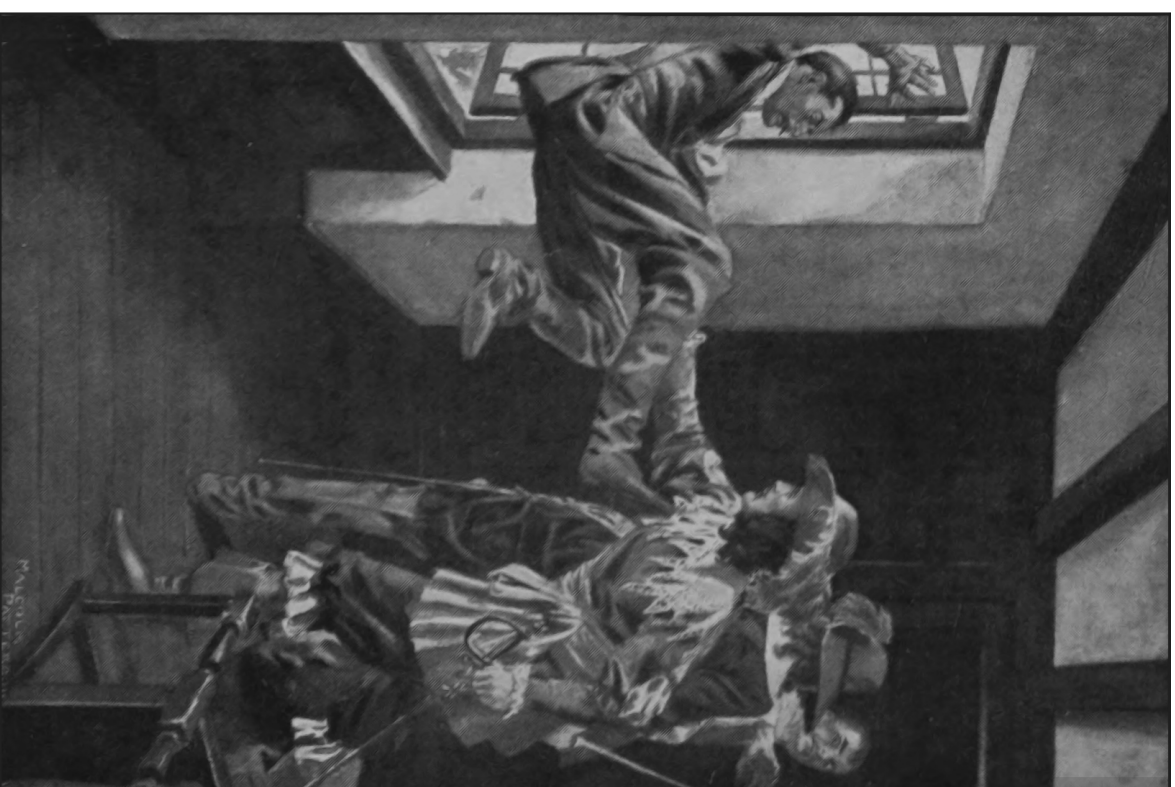
'Monsieur! you—'

'Accept it, I say. To-day is with me a day of mourning; hereafter you will, perhaps, learn why; to-day I have lost one friend; well, I will try to get another.'

'But, Monsieur Fouquet—'

'Adieu! Monsieur d'Artagnan, adieu!' cried Fouquet, with much emotion; 'or rather, au revoir.' And the minister quitted the cabinet, leaving in the hands of the musketeer the ring and the twenty thousand livres.

'Oh!' said D'Artagnan, after a moment's dark reflection. 'How on earth am I to understand what this means? Mordieux! I can understand this much, only: he is a gallant man! I will go and explain matters to M. Colbert.' And he went out.



RAOUL THREW HIM OUT OF THE WINDOW

'A thing agreed upon that you should burn my house!' vociferated D'Artagnan, snatching the brand from the hand of the incendiary, and striking him with it across the face. The second wanted to assist his comrade, but Raoul, seizing him by the middle, threw him out of the window, whilst D'Artagnan pushed his man down the stairs. Raoul, first disengaged, tore the burning wainscoting down, and threw it flaming into the chamber. At a glance D'Artagnan saw there was nothing to be feared from the fire, and sprang to the window. The disorder was at its height. The air was filled with simultaneous cries of 'To the fire!' 'To the death!' 'To the halter!' 'To the stake!' 'Vive Colbert!' 'Vive le roi!' The group which had forced the culprits from the hands of the archers had drawn close to the house, which appeared to be the goal towards which they dragged them. Menneville was at the head of this group, shouting louder than all the others, 'To the fire! to the fire! Vive Colbert! D'Artagnan began to comprehend what was meant. They wanted to burn the condemned, and his house was to serve as a funeral pile.

'Halt, there!' cried he, sword in hand, and one foot upon the window. 'Menneville, what do you want to do?'

'Monsieur d'Artagnan,' cried the latter, 'give way, give way!'

'To the fire! to the fire with the thieves! Vive Colbert!'

These cries exasperated D'Artagnan. 'Mordoux!' said he. 'What! burn the poor devils who are only condemned to be hung? that is infamous!'

Before the door, however, the mass of anxious spectators, rolled back against the walls, had become more thick, and closed up the way. Menneville and his men, who were dragging along the culprits, were within ten paces of the door.

Menneville made a last effort. 'Passage! passage!' cried he, pistol in hand.

'Burn them! burn them!' repeated the crowd. 'The Image-de-Notre-Dame is on fire! Burn the thieves! burn the monopolists in the Image-de-Notre-Dame!'

There now remained no doubt, it was plainly D'Artagnan's house that was their object. D'Artagnan remembered the old cry, always so effective from his mouth: 'A moi! mousquetaires!' shouted he, with the voice of a giant, with one of those voices which dominate over cannon, the sea, the tempest. 'A moi! mousquetaires!' And suspending himself by the arm from the balcony, he allowed himself to drop amidst the crowd, which began to draw back from a house that rained men. Raoul was on the ground as soon as he, both sword in

Chapter LXIV

Difference D'Artagnan Finds Between the Intendant and the Superintendent



. Colbert resided in the Rue Neuve des Petits-Champs, in a house which had belonged to Beautrü. D'Artagnan's legs cleared the distance in a short quarter of an hour. When he arrived at the residence of the new favourite, the court was full of archers and police, who came to congratulate him, or to excuse themselves, according to whether he should choose to praise or blame. The sentiment of flattery is instinctive with people of abject condition; they have the sense of it, as the wild animal has that of hearing and smell. These people, or their leader, understood that there was a pleasure to offer to M. Colbert, in rendering him an account of the fashion in which his name had been pronounced during the rash enterprise of the morning. D'Artagnan made his appearance just as the chief of the watch was giving his report. He stood close to the door, behind the archers. That officer took Colbert on one side, in spite of his resistance and the contradiction of his busy eyebrows. 'In case,' said he, 'you really desired, monsieur, that the people should do justice on the two traitors, it would have been wise to warn us of it; for, indeed, monsieur, in spite of our regret at displeasing you, or thwarting your views, we had our orders to execute.'

'Triple fool!' replied Colbert, furiously shaking his hair, thick and black as a mane; 'what are you telling me? What! that I could have had an idea of a riot! Are you mad or drunk?'

‘But, monsieur, they cried “Vive Colbert!”’ replied the trembling watch.
‘A handful of conspirators—’

‘No, no; a mass of people.’

‘Ah! indeed,’ said Colbert, expanding. ‘A mass of people cried “Vive Colbert!” Are you certain of what you say, monsieur?’

‘We had nothing to do but open our ears, or rather to close them, so terrible were the cries.’

‘And this was from the people, the real people?’

‘Certainly, monsieur; only these real people beat us.’

‘Oh! very well,’ continued Colbert, thoughtfully. ‘Then you suppose it was the people alone who wished to burn the condemned?’

‘Oh! yes, monsieur.’

‘That is quite another thing. You strongly resisted, then?’

‘We had three of our men crushed to death, monsieur!’

‘But you killed nobody yourselves?’

‘Monsieur, a few of the rioters were left upon the square, and one among them who was not a common man.’

‘Who was he?’

‘A certain Menneville, upon whom the police have a long time had an eye.’

‘Menneville!’ cried Colbert, ‘what, he who killed Rue de la Huchette, a worthy man who wanted a fat fowl!’

‘Yes, monsieur; the same.’

‘And did this Menneville also cry, “Vive Colbert!”?’

‘Louder than all the rest, like a madman.’

Colbert’s brow grew dark and wrinkled. A kind of ambitious glory which had lighted his face was extinguished, like the light of glow-worms we crush beneath the grass. ‘Then you say,’ resumed the deceived intendant, ‘that the initiative came from the people? Menneville was my enemy; I would have had him hung, and he knew it well. Menneville belonged to the Abbé Fouquet—the affair originated with Fouquet; does not everybody know that the condemned were his friends from childhood?’

‘That is true,’ thought D’Arragnan, ‘and thus are all my doubts cleared up. I repeat it, Monsieur Fouquet may be called what they please, but he is a very gentlemanly man.’

‘And,’ continued Colbert, ‘are you quite sure Menneville is dead?’

those men, of whom D’Arragnan never lost sight, fell upon the escort, which in vain endeavoured to stand against them. Behind these men was the crowd. Then commenced, amidst a frightful tumult, as frightful a confusion. This time there was something more than cries of expectation or cries of joy, there were cries of pain. Halberds struck men down, swords ran through them, muskets were discharged at them. The confusion became then so great that D’Arragnan could no longer distinguish anything. Then, from this chaos, suddenly surged something like a visible intention, like a will pronounced. The condemned had been torn from the hands of the guards, and were being dragged towards the house of L’Image-de-Notre-Dame. Those who dragged them shouted, ‘Vive Colbert!’ The people hesitated, not knowing which they ought to fall upon, the archers or the aggressors. What stopped the people was, that those who cried ‘Vive Colbert!’ began to cry, at the same time, ‘No halter! no halter! to the fire! to the fire! burn the thieves! burn the extortioners!’ This cry, shouted with an ensemble, obtained enthusiastic success. The populace had come to witness an execution, and here was an opportunity offered them of performing one themselves. It was this that must be most agreeable to the populace: therefore, they ranged themselves immediately on the party of the aggressors against the archers, crying with the minority, which had become, thanks to them, the most compact majority: ‘Yes, yes: to the fire with the thieves! Vive Colbert!’

‘Mordionx!’ exclaimed D’Arragnan, ‘this begins to look serious.’

One of the men who remained near the chimney approached the window, a firebrand in his hand. ‘Ah, ah!’ said he, ‘it gets warm.’ Then, turning to his companion: ‘There is the signal,’ added he; and he immediately applied the burning brand to the wainscoting. Now, this cabaret of the Image-de-Notre-Dame was not a very newly built house, and therefore, did not require much entreating to take fire. In a second the boards began to crackle, and the flames arose sparkling to the ceiling. A howling from without replied to the shouts of the incendiaries. D’Arragnan, who had not seen what passed, from being engaged at the window, felt, at the same time, the smoke which choked him and the fire that scorched him. ‘Hola!’ cried he, turning round, ‘is the fire here? Are you drunk or mad, my masters?’

The two men looked at each other with an air of astonishment. ‘In what?’ asked they of D’Arragnan; ‘was it not a thing agreed upon?’

were exchanged, hands given and taken. D'Artagnan remarked among the groups, and those groups the most animated, the face of the cavalier whom he had seen enter by the door of communication from his garden, and who had gone upstairs to harangue the drinkers. That man was organizing troops and giving orders.

'Mordieux!' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'I was not deceived; I know that man,—it is Menneville. What the devil is he doing here?'

A distant murmur, which became more distinct by degrees, stopped this reflection, and drew his attention another way. This murmur was occasioned by the arrival of the culprits; a strong picket of archers preceded them, and appeared at the angle of the arcade. The entire crowd now joined as if in one cry; all the cries united formed one immense howl. D'Artagnan saw Raoul was becoming pale, and he slapped him roughly on the shoulder. The fire-keepers turned round on hearing the great cry, and asked what was going on. 'The condemned are arrived,' said D'Artagnan. 'That's well,' replied they, again replenishing the fire. D'Artagnan looked at them with much uneasiness; it was evident that these men who were making such a fire for no apparent purpose had some strange intentions. The condemned appeared upon the Place. They were walking, the executioner before them, whilst fifty archers formed a hedge on their right and their left. Both were dressed in black; they appeared pale, but firm. They looked impatiently over the people's heads, standing on tip-toe at every step. D'Artagnan remarked this. 'Mordieux!' cried he, 'they are in a great hurry to get a sight of the gibbet!' Raoul drew back, without, however, having the power to leave the window. Terror even has its attractions.

'To the death! to the death!' cried fifty thousand voices.

'Yes; to the death!' howled a hundred frantic others, as if the great mass had given them the reply.

'To the halter! to the halter!' cried the great whole; 'Vive le roi!'

'Well,' said D'Artagnan, 'this is droll; I should have thought it was M. Colbert who had caused them to be hung.'

There was, at this moment, a great rolling movement in the crowd, which stopped for a moment the march of the condemned. The people of a bold and resolute mien, whom D'Artagnan had observed, by dint of pressing, pushing, and lifting themselves up, had succeeded in almost touching the hedge of archers. The cortège resumed its march. All at once, to cries of 'Vive Colbert!'

D'Artagnan thought the time was come for him to make his appearance. 'Perfectly, monsieur,' replied he, advancing suddenly.

'Oh! is that you, monsieur?' said Colbert.

'In person,' replied the musketeer with his deliberate tone; 'it appears that you had in Menneville a pretty enemy.'

'It was not I, monsieur, who had an enemy,' replied Colbert; 'it was the king.'

'Double brute!' thought D'Artagnan, 'to think to play the great man and the hypocrite with me. Well,' continued he to Colbert, 'I am very happy to have rendered so good a service to the king; will you take upon you to tell his majesty, monsieur l'intendant?'

'What commission is this you give me, and what do you charge me to tell his majesty, monsieur? Be precise, if you please,' said Colbert, in a sharp voice, tuned beforehand to hostility.

'I give you no commission,' replied D'Artagnan, with that calmness which never abandons the banterer; 'I thought it would be easy for you to announce to his majesty that it was I who, being there by chance, did justice upon Menneville and restored order to things.'

Colbert opened his eyes and interrogated the chief of the watch with a look—'Ah! it is very true,' said the latter, 'that this gentleman saved us.'

'Why did you not tell me, monsieur, that you came to relate me this?' said Colbert with envy; 'everything is explained, and more favourably for you than for anybody else.'

'You are in error, monsieur l'intendant, I did not at all come for the purpose of relating that to you.'

'It is an exploit, nevertheless.'

'Oh!' said the musketeer carelessly, 'constant habit blunts the mind.'

'To what do I owe the honour of your visit, then?'

'Simply to this: the king ordered me to come to you.'

'Ah!' said Colbert, recovering himself when he saw D'Artagnan draw a paper from his pocket; 'it is to demand some money of me?'

'Precisely, monsieur.'

'Have the goodness to wait, if you please, monsieur, till I have dispatched the report of the watch.'

D'Aragnan turned upon his heel, insolently enough, and finding himself face to face with Colbert, after his first turn, he bowed to him as a harlequin would have done; then, after a second evolution, he directed his steps towards the door in quick time. Colbert was struck with this pointed rudeness, to which he was not accustomed. In general, men of the sword, when they came to his office, had such a want of money, that though their feet seemed to take root in the marble, they hardly lost their patience. Was D'Aragnan going straight to the king? Would he go and describe his rough reception, or recount his exploit? This was a matter for grave consideration. At all events, the moment was badly chosen to send D'Aragnan away, whether he came from the king, or on his own account. The musketeer had rendered too great a service, and that too recently, for it to be already forgotten. Therefore Colbert thought it would be better to shake off his arrogance and call D'Aragnan back. 'Ho! Monsieur d'Aragnan,' cried Colbert, 'what! are you leaving me thus?' D'Aragnan turned round: 'Why not?' said he, quietly, 'we have no more to say to each other, have we?'

'You have, at least, money to receive, as you have an order?'

'Who, I? Oh! not at all, my dear Monsieur Colbert.'

'But, monsieur, you have an order. And, in the same manner as you give a sword-thrust, when you are required, I, on my part, pay when an order is presented to me. Present yours.'

'It is useless, my dear Monsieur Colbert,' said D'Aragnan, who inwardly enjoyed this confusion in the ideas of Colbert; 'my order is paid.'

'Paid, by whom?'

'By monsieur le surintendant.'

Colbert grew pale.

'Explain yourself,' said he, in a stifled voice—'if you are paid why do you show me that paper?'

'In consequence of the word of order of which you spoke to me so ingeniously just now, dear M. Colbert; the king told me to take a quarter of the pension he is pleased to make me.'

'Of me?' said Colbert.

'Not exactly. The king said to me: "Go to M. Fouquet; the superintendent will, perhaps, have no money, then you will go and draw it of M. Colbert."'

Chapter LXII

Vive Colbert!



HE spectacle which the Grève now presented was a frightful one. The heads, levelled by the perspective, extended afar, thick and agitated as the ears of corn in a vast plain. From time to time a fresh report, or a distant rumour, made the heads oscillate and thousands of eyes flash. Now and then there were great movements. All those ears of corn bent, and became waves more agitated than those of the ocean, which rolled from the extremities to the centre, and beat, like the tides, against the hedge of archers who surrounded the gibbets. Then the handles of the halberds were let fall upon the heads and shoulders of the rash invaders; at times, also, it was the steel as well as the wood, and, in that case, a large empty circle was formed around the guard; a space conquered upon the extremities, which underwent, in their turn the oppression of the sudden movement, which drove them against the parapets of the Seine. From the window, that commanded a view of the whole Place, D'Aragnan saw, with interior satisfaction, that such of the musketeers and guards as found themselves involved in the crowd, were able, with blows of their fists and the hilts of their swords, to keep room. He even remarked that they had succeeded, by that esprit de corps which doubles the strength of the soldier, in getting together in one group to the amount of about fifty men; and that, with the exception of a dozen stragglers whom he still saw rolling here and there, the nucleus was complete, and within reach of his voice. But it was not the musketeers and guards that drew the attention of D'Aragnan. Around the gibbets, and particularly at the entrances to the arcade of Saint-Jean, moved a noisy mass, a busy mass, daring faces, resolute demeanours were to be seen here and there, mingled with silly faces and indifferent demeanours; signals